

placed third currently, the women had two wins, with a shootout bonus against the Netherlands, to be placed sixth with nine points — already one more than what they managed in total in 2023-24.

The road ahead is, in some ways, both simpler and tougher for the men. **After two consecutive Olympic medals and a fairly well-settled system, it's more about fine-tuning what has already been proven to work, with an infusion of new faces.** The team has consistently remained among the top five in the world, and there is little to separate them from the other top teams.

The HIL gave Craig Fulton an opportunity to assess the youngsters from the junior side, and the Pro League a chance to test them in tougher situations. The eight games — two each against England, Germany, Spain and Ireland — saw the India coach rotate as many as 27 players in his search for a core group leading up to the 2026 World Cup.

Among those were youngsters like Rajinder Singh, Araijeet Singh Hundal, Arshdeep Singh and Yashdeep Siwach, players who impressed with both their skills and game intelligence on the field. With a demanding 2026 that has the World Cup and the Asian Games scheduled less than a month apart, Fulton has admitted the need to prepare more than one core team. If the start of the Pro League is any indication, Indian men's hockey is on track to do so.

Fulton knows that not all seniors in the side will continue to be active for the next four years. **Regardless of their fitness or experience, many in the side are expected to call it a day after the World Cup or the Asian Games, and a new leadership group is inevitable.** The Pro League, in that regard, is also a test of leadership skills among the newer lot.

Hundal and Arshdeep have already been marked as long-term prospects in attack, but Rajinder on the flanks was the most impressive with his stick work, control, and

accuracy in setting up goals. Fulton's mantra of defending to win was clearly visible in India's matches — the host conceded the least number of goals, 12, among all nations in the first half of the season. At the other end, however, goals have not been easy to come by, with penalty corner conversions remaining the bugbear in an otherwise sorted set-up.

India earned 30 PCs at the Kalinga Stadium, but Jugraj Singh, considered the best drag-flicker in India behind Harmanpreet Singh and coming in on the back of a red-hot streak as the top scorer in the HIL, failed to score a single goal, even when Harmanpreet



THE WOMEN'S HOCKEY TEAM IMPRESSED AND FRUSTRATED IN EQUAL MEASURE, HIGHLIGHTING INCONSISTENCY IN FORM AND FORTUNES



was rested. On the other hand, field goals from Sukhjeet, Abhishek and Mandeep Singh helped release the pressure somewhat. Clearly, the stint with Australian Michael McCann for the strikers paid off. But with Amandeep Lakra impressing and waiting for his chance, it remains to be seen if Fulton will continue to persist with Jugraj or explore other options.

The other small worry for Fulton would be the persistent slow start from the team. The Indians bounced back after every loss to win big, and while it did show that the Indians did best with their backs to the wall, it also puts them in a situation where they are left chasing, instead of setting the terms.

It's more complicated for the women. Missing the Paris Olympics meant changes in both the playing



and support staff, and while the seniors in the side have, so far, been vital to the team's prospects, coach Harendra Singh will have his hands full planning for both the long- and short-term future.

The team impressed and frustrated in equal measure, highlighting inconsistency in form and fortunes. On the positive side, the team managed hard-fought victories against England and Germany and a massive morale booster with a shootout win against the dominant Netherlands. Although